just played than I had by any game all season. The crowd, when I'd come on as a sub, had seemed a little subdued. The reception I got after the final whistle was better than any I could remember at Old Trafford. I'm always the last player off the field anyway and after the Real game I wanted to hang around and soak it up. I certainly wasn't saying goodbye to Old Trafford that night. The opposite: I thought I'd done all I could to put doubts about my commitment and worth to the club behind me. During the ninety minutes, it had been all about the team. Now, though, I let my feelings show and went to the four corners of the stadium to return the applause.

By the time I got back to the dressing room, I had Guti and Zidane's shirts under my arm. And a warm glow inside. I remember the manager saying to me quietly:

'You played well, David.'

I wondered if he thought then that he'd made a mistake about me and about the team that night. It wasn't the time, or the place, to ask.

'Yeah. Thanks, boss.'

I'd never changed and gotten out of Old Trafford so quickly. Half an hour after the game, I was at the Malmaison Hotel in Manchester to meet Tony and Ellen Healy, Pepsi's Marketing Director, for dinner. They must have thought I was on something: I was that high. I hadn't felt so clear about things, happy in myself, for what seemed like months. I wanted to talk about the game. About my goals. About the crowd. About Ronaldo and the rest of them. I had a grin on my face all evening. I kept phoning Victoria who was away working in the States. I told her everything that had happened the first time I called. But I kept phoning back to say it again. I missed her being there. I went on from the Malmaison to the Lowry to have a drink with Dave Gardner. The two of us went over the whole night again. We had to. The weirdest thing, though, happened just as I was getting ready to leave. I half thought I was being set up. This Spanish guy, a Real supporter, came over. He didn't speak much English. There was quite a lot of thumbs up and 'good game' going on. He motioned to me: an autograph. On his shirt. He turned round for me to sign. He was wearing the number. 7, Raul's shirt.

When I got back to the house in Alderley Edge, everything was quiet. Mum had got the boys off to bed for me. I poked my head in their room but decided not to wake them up and tell them about Daddy's great night. I was still hyped up: sleeping would have been out of the question. I made myself a bowl of noodles and a pint of iced water. I put the television on: Manchester